

Fossils Show an Early Human Relative Lived in Africa Earlier Than Thought

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New **fossils** from a cave in South Africa are adding to the story of early human **evolution**. Scientists say they give stronger evidence that Homo erectus, an early human relative, lived in southern Africa about 2 million years ago. That is roughly 200,000 years earlier than many researchers had long believed.

Homo erectus is the first **species** that most scientists agree belongs to our own group, called Homo. It is likely one of our direct **ancestors**.

The **fossils** come from Drimolen, a cave site in an area known as the Cradle of Humankind, one of the richest places in the world for ancient human **fossils**. The site was dug from 1992 to 2019, but many **fossils** found there had never been fully described. A team led by researchers at La Trobe University in Australia, working with scientists in South Africa and the United States, has now studied 18 more of them.

One of the **fossils** is part of an adult Homo erectus skull. An earlier Homo erectus fossil from Drimolen belonged to a young child, so scientists were not sure what adults looked like. Lead researcher Jesse Martin said the new fossil helps confirm the **species** first appeared there 2 million years ago.

The cave also holds **fossils** of another relative, Paranthropus robustus. It had a smaller brain, but over about 200,000 years it grew even bigger back teeth and stronger **chewing muscles** for crushing tough food. Meanwhile, Homo erectus was developing a larger brain and smaller teeth.

Martin said that at Drimolen, Paranthropus robustus outnumbered Homo erectus by more than 10 to one. Back then, he said, our **ancestors** looked like the "long-odds chance to survive." The study appears in the journal Annals of Human Biology.

Word Treasure

evolution -- The slow change in living things over many generations.

fossils -- Remains or traces of ancient living things preserved in rock.

ancestors -- Relatives who lived long before us, from whom we are descended.

species -- A group of living things that are alike and can have young together.

chewing muscles -- Jaw muscles that help an animal bite and grind food.

Background you need

Fossils are the preserved remains of living things from long ago, and scientists use them to learn how life has changed over time.

Humans belong to a group called Homo, and several related species lived in Africa long before modern humans appeared.

South Africa's Cradle of Humankind is a region of caves where many important fossils of human relatives have been found.

Scientists date fossils by studying the rocks and layers around them, which helps them tell when a species first appeared.

Break it down

LEAD: Fossils suggest Homo erectus appeared in southern Africa about 2 million years ago

KEY FINDING: First adult Homo erectus fossil from Drimolen

+ WHO: Team led by La Trobe University with scientists in South Africa and the US

+ WHERE: Drimolen cave, Cradle of Humankind, South Africa

+ WHAT: 18 newly described fossils

COMPARISON: Paranthropus robustus grew bigger teeth while Homo erectus grew a larger brain

EVIDENCE: Paranthropus outnumbered Homo erectus by more than 10 to one

SOURCE: Study in Annals of Human Biology

Why it matters

Each new fossil helps fill gaps in the story of how humans evolved, and this one suggests our ancestors' history in Africa began earlier than many scientists thought.

Test what you remember

1. About how long ago did *Homo erectus* live in southern Africa, according to the fossils?
 - (A) 20 million years ago
 - (B) 2 million years ago
 - (C) 20,000 years ago
 - (D) 200,000 years ago
2. What is the name of the cave where the fossils were found?
 - (A) Nuremberg
 - (B) Swartkrans
 - (C) Drimolen
 - (D) Dmanisi
3. How many fossils did the team study in this paper?
 - (A) 8
 - (B) 80
 - (C) 180
 - (D) 18
4. What new *Homo erectus* fossil was described?
 - (A) Part of an adult skull
 - (B) A footprint
 - (C) A child's tooth
 - (D) A full skeleton
5. How did *Paranthropus robustus* change over time?
 - (A) It developed bigger teeth and stronger chewing muscles
 - (B) It learned to make fire
 - (C) It became smaller
 - (D) It grew a much larger brain
6. At Drimolen, which relative was more common 2 million years ago?
 - (A) *Homo erectus*
 - (B) *Paranthropus robustus*
 - (C) Modern humans
 - (D) Chimpanzees

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Lead researcher Jesse Martin: Says the new adult fossil helps confirm that Homo erectus first appeared there 2 million years ago, and that our ancestors once looked like the long-odds survivors.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):